

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Tornado

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

If a tornado warning covers your location, shelter now in a basement or small interior room on the lowest floor of a sturdy building. Stay away from windows and cover your head and neck. A mobile home is not a safe tornado shelter.

Do now.

- ☐ **Go to the shelter**
01 Move immediately; put shoes on if within reach and take your phone without delaying. Use a designated storm shelter when accessible.
- ☐ **Protect your head**
02 Crouch low and cover your head and neck with your arms. Use a sturdy table or available cushioning for additional protection.
- ☐ **If outside or in a vehicle**
03 Get to a nearby sturdy building if safely possible. Do not shelter under an overpass. Vehicles and mobile homes offer little protection.
- ☐ **Keep listening**
04 Use local warning messages or weather radio; remain sheltered until the threat has passed and official updates permit leaving.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Go to your identified shelter without waiting for confirmation when a warning or nearby clear danger is present. Keep shoes, a light and head protection close. If in a mobile home, use a nearby sturdy shelter before conditions worsen; never attempt to outrun a tornado in traffic.

Watch for.

Do not wait to see a funnel. Darkness and rain can hide tornadoes. A watch calls for readiness; a warning calls for action.

People & practical needs.

Choose a shelter that can actually fit and be reached by everyone. Keep shoes, a light and necessary mobility aids nearby; supervise children and secure pets without blocking the route. Rehearse how a person who cannot hear warnings will be notified.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Afterward, avoid damaged buildings, broken glass and downed lines. Check for injuries and use text to let your contact know you are safe.

Questions in the field.

What if there is no basement?

Identify an interior room on the lowest usable floor of a substantial building, away from windows. Plan the shortest route there before a warning. Protect the head and neck with available protection; equipment retrieval must not delay shelter.

What if I am in a mobile home?

A mobile home is not a tornado shelter even when tied down. Arrange a nearby substantial shelter before storms arrive and move while there is safe time. Do not wait for visible damage to decide that a different location is needed.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Tornado · official guidance

<https://www.weather.gov/safety/tornado-during>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/tornado/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.